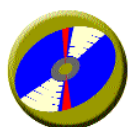


Off the Shelf



The Sum of All Fears

Adds up to a fun experience

After learning that *The Sum of All Fears* (SoAF) was not so much a *Quake*-clone as a squad-based strategy game, our combined senses raced back in time to the painful sessions of playing *Tom Clancy's Rainbow Six*. Thankfully, SoAF does not live up to its name and is both an approachable and an entertaining foray into the world of action-strategy games.

Although based on the movie, SoAF does not cast you as Jack Ryan. Instead, you play the team leader of an elite anti-terrorist squad, whose services are required after America witnesses a nuclear detonation. You and your team carefully navigate through 11 missions all over the world and neutralise hostilities. On the journey, you pick up important pieces of intelligence, disarm and plant bombs, rescue hostages, ransack vaults, and assassinate many a baddie.

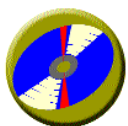


HEART-TO-HEART: Locate friends and foes alike with the help of high-tech heart beat sensors

The inclusion of real-world weaponry is elegantly handled: the MP5s are segregated from the M4s, by both the damage that each deal out and by authentic sounds that accompany them.

Unfortunately, for a squad-based game, both hostile and friendly computer-controlled entities will simultaneously amuse and dumbfound you with their lack of AI. Although the experience thus presented is not very jarring, it is further bogged down by the use of a dated 3D engine. The locales are rarely breathtaking, either in ambience or design; the textures used are similarly ordinary and ditto the animations employed. All of this, of course, means that the game is not too demanding, hardware-wise. Plus the inclusion of a meaty and thoroughly enjoyable multiplayer facet (especially over a LAN) more than redeems the game. If you wish to give your circle-strafing and bunny-hopping skills a rest and yearn for something that does not involve you jumping over exploding rockets, then you owe this game a try.

Minimum System Requirements: 450 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB DirectX 8 compatible 3D card ■ **Genre:** Action-Strategy
Developer: Red Storm Entertainment ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive ■ **Phone:** 022-8381614 ■ **Web site:** sumofallfears.ubi.com ■ **Price:** Rs 1,299
Rating: ★★☆☆☆



Hired Team: Trial Gold

An asinine mettle

Imagine a world where crime and violence are so rampant that the government actually decides to do something about it! In *Hired Team: Trial Gold* (HTTG), such a world does exist and the government creates a strike team to put an end to the anarchy and bring the twin gifts of hope and joy to an otherwise destitute world.

It is a concept that has been attempted before and with better execution. All through the game, you run around the various levels, shooting things that dare wear a different coloured shirt! The maps feel tacky and the weapons are poorly



HAVE WE MET? Hey! I killed you five seconds ago

balanced—a pistol will get you nowhere, while a rifle has a one-shot-kill guarantee, regardless of where you hit the baddie. The

bots have an unfinished Frankenstein-monster feel to them. So don't blame them if they refuse to use the health-kit that lies next to their feet and are unaware of the protective benefits of an armour. Watch them climb over your back, pass right next to you without even a parting shot and gaze in wonder as they float around the world like brain-searching wraiths.

HTTG is a bad cocktail of an extreme effort towards *Unreal Tournament* and *Quake III Arena* and an element of originality is brought only via its interface. Go ahead, play this game, unmake your day.

Minimum System Requirements: 400 MHz processor, 64 MB RAM, OpenGL or Direct3D compatible graphics card ■ **Genre:** First Person Shooter
Developer: New Media Generation ■ **Distributor:** Aladdin Multimedia ■ **Phone:** 022-7895085/7903959 ■ **Web site:** www.nmg.ru/httrial/ ■ **Price:** Rs 499
Rating: ★★☆☆☆

